

HOUSE BILL 1653

By Eldridge

AN ACT to amend Tennessee Code Annotated, Title 4 and
Title 71, relative to the department of human
services.

BE IT ENACTED BY THE GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE:

SECTION 1. Tennessee Code Annotated, Title 71, Chapter 1, Part 1, is amended by
adding the following as a new section:

(a) The general assembly finds and declares that:

(1) Access to the printed word is a fundamental prerequisite to education,
employment, and economic independence for blind persons in this state;

(2) For more than two (2) decades, accessible information services,
including the National Federation of the Blind newsline, have been supported in
this state as part of vocational rehabilitation services and have contributed
directly to the employment, job retention, long-term economic independence, and
informed participation in civic life of blind persons in this state; and

(3) Disruptions in funding for these services have resulted from
administrative inconsistency and loss of institutional knowledge.

(b) It is the intent of the general assembly to restore clarity, stability, and
accountability in providing accessible information services to blind persons in this state.

(c) The department, through the vocational rehabilitation program, shall ensure
continued access to accessible information services for blind persons in this state, which
includes the National Federation of the Blind newsline, as part of the department's
vocational rehabilitation services.

(d) For the purpose of supporting accessible information services for blind persons in this state, it is the legislative intent that the department, through the vocational rehabilitation program, allocate a minimum of sixteen thousand dollars (\$16,000) annually in vocational rehabilitation funds. If the department allocates such funds, then the funds must be used to draw down available federal vocational rehabilitation matching funds.

(e) Funds allocated pursuant to this section may be used:

(1) To maintain access to accessible information services; and

(2) To support outreach, training, and marketing activities designed to increase utilization of vocational rehabilitation services for employment and education-related purposes. These activities may include consumer education, emergency services, employer-related outreach, and assistance to vocational rehabilitation clients in using accessible information tools to seek and retain employment.

(f) The department shall maintain documentation of funding sources related to accessible information services funded pursuant to this section.

SECTION 2. This act takes effect July 1, 2026, the public welfare requiring it.